

سُورَةُ الْقَارِعَةِ

101

Sūrat al-Qāri‘ah

The Striking Calamity — an āyah-by-āyah tafsīr

Drawing on Ibn Kathīr • as-Sa‘dī • al-Jalālayn • aṭ-Ṭabarī • al-Qurṭubī • al-Baghawī

The Sūrah at a glance

11

āyāt

101

in muṣḥaf order

30

juz' ('Ammā)

Makkī

by consensus

Names of the sūrah

- Al-Qāri'ah — “the Striking Calamity”, from āyah 1
- Al-Qāri'ah is itself a name of the Day of Resurrection

Central theme

The Day that strikes the hearts: people like scattered moths, mountains like carded wool. Then the scales — heavy scales lead to a pleasing life, light scales to Hāwiyah, a blazing Fire.

What makes the scales heavy

Authentic aḥādīth on the Mīzān — the centre of this sūrah

The Prophet ﷺ said:

“Two words, light on the tongue, heavy on the Scale, beloved to the Most Merciful: Subḥān-Allāhi wa bi-ḥamdih, Subḥān-Allāhil-‘Azīm.”

— Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī & Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim

“Nothing is heavier on the Scale than good character.” — Abū Dāwūd, at-Tirmidhī

The Scale is real

Ahl as-Sunnah affirm a real Mīzān with two pans, in which deeds are weighed (al-Anbiyā’ 21:47).

Small deeds, heavy weight

Dhikr and good character — light to carry, heavy where it counts.

The tafsīr sources in this deck



Ibn Kathīr

d. 774 AH

Tafsīr al-Qur'ān al-'Aẓīm — explains Qur'ān by Qur'ān, then Sunnah, then the Companions and Tābi'ūn.



as-Sa'dī

d. 1376 AH

Taysīr al-Karīm ar-Raḥmān — concise, focused on meanings, guidance and practical lessons.



al-Jalālayn

al-Maḥallī & as-Suyūṭī

Tafsīr al-Jalālayn — a word-by-word gloss; brief and precise in its definitions.



Others

aṭ-Ṭabarī • al-Qurṭubī • al-Baghawī

Used for the range of early opinions, language and further points.

Note: tafsīr points are summarised and paraphrased in English — check against the Arabic originals before teaching.

Three movements in eleven āyāt

1-3

The Striking Day

A name repeated three times to fill the heart with its awe.

4-5

The great upheaval

People like scattered moths;
mountains like carded, coloured wool.

6-11

The Scales

Heavy scales: a pleasing life. Light scales: Hāwiyah — a blazing Fire.

Āyah 1–3 · The Striking Calamity



الْقَارِعَةُ ﴿١﴾ مَا الْقَارِعَةُ ﴿٢﴾ وَمَا أَدْرَاكَ مَا الْقَارِعَةُ

The Striking Calamity — what is the Striking Calamity? And what can make you know what the Striking Calamity is?

Ibn Kathīr

Al-Qāri‘ah is one of the names of the Day of Resurrection, like al-Ḥāqqah, aṭ-Ṭāmmah, aṣ-Ṣākhkhah and al-Ghāshiyah. Allah then magnifies its matter and makes it awesome.

as-Sa‘dī

It is so named because it strikes people and their hearts with its terrors. The repeated question is to magnify it.

al-Jalālayn

The Hour that strikes the hearts with its terrors. “What is...” and “what can make you know...” both magnify its affair.

Āyah 4 • Like scattered moths



يَوْمَ يَكُونُ النَّاسُ كَالْفَرَاشِ الْمَبْثُوثِ

It is the Day when people will be like moths, dispersed,

Ibn Kathīr

Like scattered moths in their spreading, confusion and coming and going — as in “like locusts spreading” (al-Qamar 54:7).

as-Sa‘dī

From the terror, people are like moths: scattered, crowding, colliding into one another, not knowing where to turn.

al-Jalālayn

Like small flying insects scattered about, surging into one another in confusion until they are called to the Reckoning.

Āyah 5 · Mountains like carded wool



وَتَكُونُ الْجِبَالُ كَالْعِهْنِ الْمَنْفُوشِ

And the mountains will be like wool, fluffed up.

Ibn Kathīr

‘Ihn is wool (Mujāhid and others). The mountains become like carded wool, beginning to break apart and vanish.

as-Sa‘dī

Like dyed wool that has been carded: weak and light, then they become scattered dust and are gone.

al-Jalālayn

Like carded wool in the lightness of its movement, until they are levelled with the earth.

Āyah 6–7 · Heavy scales, pleasing life



فَأَمَّا مَنْ ثَقُلَتْ مَوَازِينُهُ ﴿٦﴾ فَهُوَ فِي عِيشَةٍ رَّاضِيَةٍ

Then as for one whose scales are heavy [with good deeds], he will be in a pleasant life.

Ibn Kathīr

One whose good deeds outweigh his evil deeds will be in a pleasing life — in Paradise.

as-Sa‘dī

His good deeds outweigh his bad, so he lives a pleasing life in the gardens of bliss.

al-Jalālayn

Whose good deeds outweigh the bad.
‘Īshah rāḍiyah: in Paradise — a life he is pleased with.

Āyah 8–9 • Light scales: Hāwiyah



وَأَمَّا مَنْ خَفَّتْ مَوَازِينُهُ ﴿٨﴾ فَأُمُّهُ هَاوِيَةٌ

But as for one whose scales are light, his refuge will be an abyss.

Ibn Kathīr

He falls headlong into the Fire. Some said “umm” is his head — he plunges on it; others: Hāwiyah is his abode, embracing him as a mother embraces her child.

as-Sa‘dī

His abode and dwelling is Hāwiyah, one of the names of the Fire. It is called his “mother” because it holds him close as a mother holds her child.

al-Jalālayn

Ummuhu: his abode. Hāwiyah: the Fire into which he falls.

Āyah 10–11 · A blazing Fire



وَمَا أَدْرَاكَ مَا هِيَ ﴿١٠﴾ نَارٌ حَامِيَةٌ

And what can make you know what that is? It is a Fire, intensely hot.

Ibn Kathīr

Intensely hot, burning fiercely. He cites the ḥadīth: “Your fire is one part of seventy parts of the fire of Jahannam” (al-Bukhārī, Muslim).

as-Sa‘dī

It is a fire of extreme heat, scorching and burning.

al-Jalālayn

Mā hiyah: what is Hāwiyah? The hā’ is for the pause (hā’ as-sakt). Ḥāmiyah: of intense heat.

Key words of the sūrah

al-qāri‘ah

that which strikes — the Hour

القَارِعَةُ

al-farāsh

moths, small flying insects

الْفَرَاشِ

al-mabthūth

scattered, spread out

المَبْثُوثُ

al-‘ihn

wool, dyed wool

الْعِهْنُ

al-manfūsh

carded, fluffed up

الْمَنْفُوشِ

mawāzīnuhu

his scales / weighed deeds

مَوَازِينُهُ

hāwiyah

abyss — a name of the Fire

هَآوِيَةٍ

ḥāmiyah

intensely hot

حَامِيَةٍ

From the wider tafsīr tradition

aṭ-Ṭabarī

Explains al-farāsh as the small creatures that fall into fire and lamps, and al-mabthūth as spread about — people likened to them in their number and confusion.

al-Qurṭubī

Notes the plural mawāzīn: either many scales, one for each person or deed, or the weighed deeds themselves. Either way, the weighing is real.

al-Baghawī

On “ummuhu hāwiyah”: as a mother is a child’s refuge, the Fire becomes this person’s only refuge — a phrase of severe warning.

Two scales, two endings

ثَقُلْتُ مَوَازِينَهُ

Heavy scales

- Good deeds outweigh the bad
- Dhikr, good character, sincerity
- ‘Īshah rāḍiyah — a pleasing life

→ Jannah, gardens of bliss

خَفَّتْ مَوَازِينَهُ

Light scales

- Evil outweighs the good
- Deeds empty of sincerity or faith
- Ummuhu hāwiyah — his only refuge

→ A Fire, intensely hot

Lessons to carry



Feel the awe

The Qur'ān repeats al-Qāri'ah to move the heart (āyāt 1–3).



Nothing here lasts

If mountains become wool, what of our plans? (āyah 5)



Light words, heavy rewards

Dhikr and good character fill the Scale.



Status will vanish

All people become like moths, equal in confusion (āyah 4).



Weigh your deeds now

The Scale is coming — add to it daily (āyāt 6–9).



Take the warning seriously

Our fire is a fraction of that Fire (āyāt 10–11).

فَأَمَّا مَنْ ثَقُلَتْ مَوَازِينُهُ ﴿٦﴾ فَهُوَ فِي عِيشَةٍ رَاضِيَةٍ

“As for one whose scales are heavy, he will be in a pleasing life.” — 101:6–7



References

Ibn Kathīr, Tafsīr al-Qur’ān al-‘Aẓīm · as-Sa’dī, Taysīr al-Karīm ar-Raḥmān · al-Maḥallī & as-Suyūṭī, Tafsīr al-Jalālayn · aṭ-Ṭabarī, Jāmi‘ al-Bayān · al-Qurṭubī, al-Jāmi‘ li-Aḥkām al-Qur’ān · al-Baghawī, Ma‘ālim at-Tanzīl · Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 3265, 6406; Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 2694, 2843; Abū Dāwūd 4799; at-Tirmidhī 2002